

SOCIAL INEQUALITY AND EXCLUSION

WHAT IS SOCIAL ABOUT SOCIAL INEQUALITY AND EXCLUSION?

- 1 Social inequality and exclusion are social because they are not about individuals but about groups.
- 2 They are social in the sense that they are not economic, although there is usually a strong link between social and economic inequality.
- 3 They are systematic and structured – there is a definite pattern to social inequalities.

**Caste is part of the Silicon Valley ecosystem: Equality Labs**

Last week, a landmark lawsuit against a major IT firm in the US made news – the state of California's

SOCIAL INEQUALITY AND EXCLUSION

SOCIAL INEQUALITY

1 Patterns of unequal access to social resources are commonly called social inequality.

2 Social resources can be divided into three forms of capital

- **Economic capital** in the form of material assets and income.
- **Cultural capital** such as educational qualifications and status.
- **Social capital** in the form of networks of contacts and social associations.

3 Often, these three forms of capital overlap and one can be converted into the other.



4

FOR EXAMPLE

i

A person from a well-off family (economic capital) can afford expensive higher education, and so can acquire cultural or educational capital.

ii

Someone with influential relatives and friends (social capital) may – through access to good advice, recommendations or information – manage to get a well-paid job.

5

However, by and large, social inequality is not the outcome of innate or 'natural' differences between people, but is produced by the society in which they live.



1 Social stratification refers to a system by which categories of people in a society are ranked in a hierarchy.

2 This hierarchy then shapes people's identity and experiences, their relations with others, as well as unequal access to resources and opportunities.

1 Social stratification is a characteristic of society, not simply a function of individual differences.

2 Social stratification persists over generations.

3 Social stratification is supported by patterns of belief, or ideology.



3 Typically, people with the greatest social privileges express the strongest support for systems of stratification such as caste and race.

4 Those who have experienced the exploitation and humiliation of being at the bottom of the hierarchy are most likely to challenge it.

5 Social discrimination refers to actual behaviour towards another group or individual based on prejudices.

6 Discriminatory behaviour or practices may be presented as motivated by other, more justifiable, reasons like merit rather than prejudice.



SOCIAL EXCLUSION

- 1 Social exclusion refers to ways in which individuals may become cut off from full involvement in the wider society.
- 2 Prevent individuals or groups from having opportunities open to the majority of the population.
- 3 Social exclusion is sometimes wrongly justified by saying that the excluded group itself does not wish to participate.
- 4 Social exclusion is not accidental but systematic and involuntary– it is the result of structural features of society.
- 5 Prolonged experience of discriminatory or insulting behaviour often produces a reaction on the part of the excluded who then stop trying for inclusion.
- 6 For example, 'Upper' caste Hindu communities have often denied entry into temples for the 'lower' castes and specially the Dalits.



SOCIAL EXCLUSION

7 After decades of such treatment, the Dalits may build their own temple, or convert to another religion like Buddhism, Christianity or Islam.

8 India like most societies has been marked by acute practices of social discrimination and exclusion.

9 Despite various protest movements against caste, gender and religious discrimination, prejudices remain and often, new ones emerge.

10 Legislation alone is unable to transform society or produce lasting social change. A constant social campaign to change awareness and sensitivity is required to break them.



- 1 Indian social institution that legitimises and enforces practices of discrimination against people born into particular castes.
- 2 Untouchability is an extreme and particularly vicious aspect of the caste system and is a pan-Indian phenomenon.
- 3 It prescribes stringent social sanctions against members of castes located at the bottom of the purity-pollution scale often based on notions of 'distance pollution'
- 4 Unlike other (i.e., 'touchable') low castes, untouchability involved three main dimensions namely, exclusion, humiliation-subordination and exploitation



5 Dalits experience forms of exclusion that are unique and not practised against other groups – for instance, being prohibited from sharing drinking water sources or participating in collective religious worship, social ceremonies and festivals

6 Also involve forced inclusion in a subordinated role, such as being compelled to play the drums at a religious event and economic exploitation through the imposition of forced, unpaid (or under-paid) labour, or the confiscation of property.

7 untouchables' have been referred to collectively by many names which are all derogatory and carry a strongly pejorative charge.



8 In fact, many of them continue to be used as forms of abuse even today, although their use is now a criminal offence.

9 While Mahatma Gandhi had popularised the term 'Harijan' in 1930s, the ex-untouchable communities and their leaders have coined another term, 'Dalit', which is now the generally accepted term for referring to these groups.

10 It received wide currency during the caste riots in Mumbai in the early 1970s.

11 The Dalit Panthers, a radical group that emerged in western India during that time, used the term to assert their identity as part of their struggle for rights and dignity.



THE OTHER BACKWARD CLASSES

- 1 Large group of castes that were of low status and were also subjected to varying levels of discrimination short of untouchability.
- 2 These were the service and artisanal castes who occupied the lower rungs of the caste hierarchy.
- 3 Constitution of India recognises the possibility that there may be groups other than the Scheduled Tribes and Scheduled Castes who suffer from social disadvantages.
- 4 These groups – which need not be based on caste alone, but generally are identified by caste – were described as the ‘socially and educationally backward classes’ and also called ‘other backward classes’.
- 5 OBCs are a much more diverse group than the Dalits or adivasis.
- 6 They are about 41% of the national population.



1 Like the term Dalit, the term Adivasi connotes political awareness and the assertion of rights.

2 Since the middle of the nineteenth century, non-tribals have moved into the tribal districts of central India, while tribal people from the same districts have migrated to plantations, mines, factories and other places of employment.

3 In the areas where tribal populations are concentrated, their economic and social conditions are usually much worse than those of non-tribals.



TRIBES

- 4** Post-independence, their lives are not made easier
- a** Government **monopoly over forests continued**. If anything, the exploitation of forests accelerated.
 - b** The policy of capital-intensive industrialisation adopted by the Indian government required **mineral resources and power-generation capacities which were concentrated in Adivasi areas**.
 - c** Adivasi lands were rapidly acquired for new mining and dam projects.

- d** Processes continue to prevail and have become even more powerful since the 1990s when economic liberalisation policies were officially adopted by the Indian government.
- e** It is now easier for corporate firms to acquire large areas of land by displacing adivasis.



STATE AND NON-STATE INITIATIVES ADDRESSING CASTE AND TRIBE DISCRIMINATION



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- 1 Indian state has had special programmes for the Scheduled Tribes and Scheduled Castes since even before Independence.
- 2 Schedules' listing the castes and tribes recognised as deserving of special treatment are continued post-independence
- 3 Initiatives to end, prohibit and punish caste and tribe discrimination, specially untouchability.

- Constitution abolished untouchability (Article 17)
- Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act of 1989.
- Schedule V and VI for protection of tribes
- Categorization of PVTGs.



STATE AND NON-STATE INITIATIVES ADDRESSING CASTE AND TRIBE DISCRIMINATION



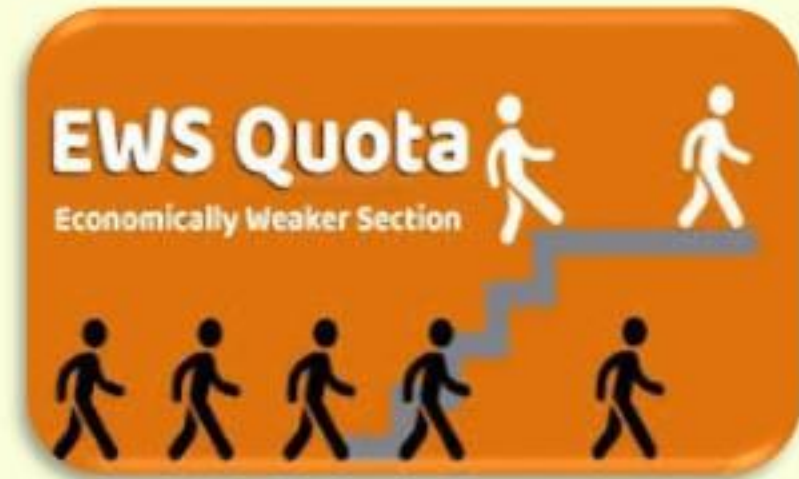
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4 Most important state initiative attempting to compensate for past and present caste discrimination is the one popularly known as 'reservations'.

5 Significant addition to such policy is the extension of reservations to the Other Backward Classes (OBCs) since the early 1990s.

6 Recently, 103rd CAA added 10% reservations for economically weaker sections.

7 Proportion of reserved seats is equal to the percentage share of the Scheduled Castes and Tribes in the total population. But for the OBCs this proportion is decided differently.



HISTORY OF RESERVATIONS

- Hindu Social order – Reservation of a kind that is of social dignity based on birth
- Formal recognition of reservation to scheduled groups by colonial rule through 1935 act.

IN PRACTICE

1. Shahu Maharaj – Raja of Kolhapur – 50% seats for non-brahmins in his court;
2. 1910's to 20's – Justice party movement.



**Shahu
Maharaj**

RESERVATIONS APPLICABLE IN

1 POLITICAL REPRESENTATION

- Issue of first past the post system
- Representatives carry the writ of majority.

2 EDUCATIONAL INSTITUTIONS

- Multi-layered education
- Discrimination in subjective evaluation
- Psychological burden – lifelong devaluation
- Equal quality education for all- no need of reservations

3 PUBLIC EMPLOYMENT

- Still SCs and STs share very little percentage of higher bureaucratic posts.
- Casteism in Private sector

RESERVATION QUOTA IN INDIA FOR GOVERNMENT JOBS

Reservation Category	Reservation Quota (%)
ST	7.5
SC	15
OBC	27
EWS	10
TOTAL	59.50

PROTESTS FOR RESERVATIONS

- 1 Land owning upper castes fell prey to failure of agriculture and found unemployed due to lack of jobs creation.
- 2 Political parties put the blame on reservations being enjoyed by certain groups shrouding their policy failures.
- 3 Politically flared up protests quickly turn as protests of aggrieved communities in disbelief that their unemployment and poverty status is because of the jobs grabbed by groups under reservation.



NEED OF THE HOUR

Collectivisation of all sections across the caste to demand more quality education institutions, job creation avenues from government.

Restructuring the existing reservation policy to let benefits reach the needed groups like Sub-Categorisation as per Justice Rohini Commission.



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For Suggestions:

suggestions@learningspace.in

To Contact us:

info@learningspace.in

For Information:

info.learningspacedigital@gmail.com

Visit us at:

www.learningspacedigital.com

0866 244 44 72

98499 42299

94415 27588